

The Hour Now Is for True Worship

God cycles me back to worship, adding different pieces each time. When He visited me and said, "You know very little about worship," He prescribed a daily period so I could break through. Within a week or two, Tim slipped under my door an article from Rick Joyner's new book. I had just begun breaking through, and many statements matched what I had heard in my spirit.

God increasingly clarified the difference between Old Covenant worship and the worship now available to sons and daughters possessing His nature.

Romans remained closed to me until the Spirit settled that chapter 7 describes an unregenerated Jew receiving a law he cannot keep. Paul asks whether the law is sin and answers emphatically, "God forbid." He would not have recognized sin unless the law said, "Thou shalt not covet." A spiritually dead person, born into that condition, cannot know anything beyond his nature until God's command exposes it.

That distinction also unlocks Jesus' statement that true worshipers worship in spirit and truth.

Jesus told the Samaritan woman:

The hour cometh, and now is, when the true worshippers shall worship the Father in spirit and in truth.

"The hour now is" identifies the hour awaited by every Old Testament saint. Since Adam's fall, no previous generation possessed this position. The lowercase *spirit* refers to the born-again human spirit.

Books often interpret the phrase as worship in the Holy Spirit or beginning in flesh and finally entering a spiritual feeling. Those ideas may contain practical truth, but they miss the doctrine. The worship itself became newly possible through rebirth.

Old Testament saints could worship from the soul and love God sincerely, but they did not possess His nature. Under the New Covenant, no one needs merely to teach his neighbor to know God, for His laws are written in heart and mind. The believer receives a nature aligned with those laws.

Romans 7's man says, "The good I would I do not, but the evil which I would not, that I do." How could he worship from a spirit still governed by death? But this new hour brought a new nature.

Jesus said at Jacob's well:

If thou knewest the gift of God...thou wouldest have asked of him, and he would have given thee living water.

The gift cannot be earned and gives no room for boasting. Jesus said ordinary water leaves a person thirsty, but His water becomes a well springing into everlasting life.

The woman initially understood only natural water. When Jesus revealed her five husbands and present relationship, she recognized Him as a prophet and asked whether worship belonged on the Samaritan mountain or in Jerusalem.

Jesus answered that geography was ending as worship's defining condition:

God is a Spirit: and they that worship him must worship him in spirit and in truth.

The condition is not a mountain or city, but the new birth. Within the well of the regenerated spirit is worship the Father waited four thousand years to receive.

We are in a war zone, busy with redemption, prayer, ministry, work, and provision. Yet the Father is not too busy for us. He runs the universe and still stops to enjoy fellowship with each child. We are the ones who claim to have no time.

Work for God never replaces fellowship with Him. Reward may relate to service, but His love does not. He longs for His children to climb into His arms and give Him the closeness for which redemption paid.

What will He want from us ages after redemption's work is complete? He saved us for fellowship. Worship is adoration that cannot stop forming words of love.

In heaven, restraint will be gone and worship spontaneous. Why wait until then? Worship freely chosen in a weak body, amid warfare and contrary feelings, gives Him something we may never offer in quite the same way again.

The article Tim gave me described someone in heaven longing to return briefly to even a dreary earthly worship service. One person worshipping from earth's darkness touched the Father more deeply than millions worshipping amid heaven's glory.

The vision showed the Father's immeasurable majesty, galaxies like curtains and His robe composed of living stars. Then all heaven stopped as He beheld the cross. The Son's love for His Father through pain and darkness moved Him until heaven and earth shook.

Next came a battered little church. Every person faced severe trials, but no one prayed about personal needs. They composed songs of thanksgiving. Their joy was sincere.

Heaven wept because tears filled the Father's eyes. These apparently defeated people had moved Him, not with pain, but joy.

When I read this after breaking into worship, I collapsed. Earlier in life it might have meant little. Now I recognized statements the Spirit had taught me.

Hebrews says:

He that cometh to God must believe that he is, and that he is a rewarder of them that diligently seek him.

We must believe He is the great I AM, the sum of all He declared Himself to be. Christ completed redemption two thousand years ago and established the law of the Spirit of life, including healing and provision. He is not deciding anew whether to provide. The decision was completed at the cross.

If we do not settle that He would have healed whenever healing could be received, we remain uncertain and eventually abort prayer. Generation-changing faith requires enough conviction to remain until He who *is* becomes the Rewarder.

I once placed God on trial emotionally when answers failed, though I would never admit it. Now nothing within accuses Him. I know His provision and character. Therefore I can remain for the duration.

Worship in the worst conditions now makes sense. Until the last judgment and every tear is wiped away, freely chosen trust can move Him profoundly.

On the cross, the firstborn Son worshiped through agony:

Father, forgive them; for they know not what they do.

And:

Father, into thy hands I commend my spirit.

The Father's emotion shook earth and darkened the sky. Jesus would have endured it for even the least believer because of that believer's potential to bring the Father joy.

Church should therefore be more than religion. We should not arrive with folded arms saying, "Get to me, God." We should enter expecting Him to reach the lost and watching for people to run to the altar.

If my life ended prematurely, never accuse God of cutting it short. He desires me here saving, teaching, walking in glory, and telling others about Him. Knowing this has transformed my faith.

When you do not know what to do with the mind during long seeking, do whatever is necessary, but do not abort. Believe He is and rewards diligence.

I wrestled with why God allowed Satan to turn his life against creation. Some say Adam had redemption because he had a tempter while Satan did not. But the angels who followed Satan had a tempter, so that answer was incomplete.

Why did God not immediately annihilate Satan and prevent Eden? Understanding God's attributes answered the question and established faith.

His essence includes sovereignty, righteousness, justice, immutability, love, eternal life, omnipotence, omniscience, and omnipresence. He cannot render an unjust judgment, act outside love, or change His nature.

When God grants life, He grants it sovereignly. Satan used his life against God and received a rebellious nature, yet remained alive. Adam likewise exercised a sovereign will. God could not simply erase either creature or replace the nature as though no choice occurred.

The Spirit whispered, "Sovereign love cannot reign as a dictator."

That truth melted me. Angels and living creatures worship because they choose and delight in an inexhaustible God. Every moral creature has a will because God is not a dictator.

God takes no pleasure in burning animals. Sacrifices mattered because they made fellowship with fallen people possible.

Jesus said:

Lo, I come in the volume of the book...to do thy will, O God.

In Gethsemane His humanity prayed:

If it be possible, let this cup pass from me: nevertheless not as I will, but as thou wilt.

If another way could redeem humanity, the Father would not have required the cup. But immutable holiness could not change, and sovereign love would not violate human will. Calvary was the only way.

Consider the cost of preserving human choice: multitudes used their freedom to reject God. Yet He paid that astronomical price so each person could freely choose Him.

That is why worship amid trouble moves Him. Hell may press from front and rear, circumstances may accuse God, and nothing may appear good. Yet the will He purchased at such cost turns freely and says, "I love You. I accept no accusation against You. I know You are doing everything love can do."

Knowing God's character tells me what He will and will not do. I can trust His promises because He cannot change.

The Father knows better than anyone what our freedom cost. When we choose Him, He delights in that choice.

I thank God for the born-again trail and the ability to give Him worship from my new nature. He waited through millennia for this fellowship. Redemption made me His son and lets me draw close to His heart through eternity.

Even in the middle of warfare, I will give Him what He wants. He has given me everything. All He wants is me.

You do not have to yell at or threaten Him. He simply wants you. Stand, and worship Him from your heart.